

Which English accent is the oldest?

哪一种英语口语历史最悠久？

2026 年 8 月 16 日 · 中英对照阅读

配套音频与原文: <https://www.bbc.co.uk/learningenglish/chinese/features/take-away-english/ep-260817>

据估计，英国拥有大约 40 到 60 种地方英语口语。许多人认为，听上去更优雅、更具格调的南方口音才是英国上流社会人士或历史剧中人物所说的英语。不过，只要对英国的语言发展历史稍加了解，就会发现南方口音很可能并非英国最古老的口音。英语的演变历程比大多数人想象的更加复杂和曲折。阅读本文，了解英语发展史上的几个重要阶段，以及最古老的英语口语最有可能来自哪个地区。

词汇: language 语言

1 Would you like to speak with a British accent? What if I told you that there is no singular 'British' accent? In fact, linguists estimate that there are 40-60 regional accents across the UK, some of which exist very close together geographically. For instance, you can listen to Manchester's 'Mancunian' accent and then Liverpool's distinct 'Scouse' accent after just a 50-minute car or train ride. Some southern English accents, such as 'Received Pronunciation', are associated with social prestige, but can the south claim to have the oldest English accent? Or does another UK region take the title? The story is messier than you might expect.

2 The first version of English, Old English, originated in the 5th and 6th centuries when tribes from northern Germany arrived in east England, a region now called 'East Anglia'. Their Germanic languages mixed with existing Latin and Celtic languages and became Old English. "It makes sense to think of East Anglia as being the source of the earliest variety of English as we know it," says Kerri-Ann Butcher, a lecturer in English Language at the University of Leeds. Over the next few centuries, English absorbed many other languages arriving from places like the Netherlands and Scandinavia. The associated linguistic changes did not happen in an orderly way across the country.

3 With all these different influences, the English language became messy and inconsistent. But in 1476, some spelling norms became standardised with the arrival of the printing press. Nowadays, the words 'blood', 'food' and 'good', which all contain two letter Os, sound different, but back then, they might have rhymed. Between the 12th and 18th centuries, something known as the Great Vowel Shift happened, where some vowel sounds across the country changed. For example, the vowel sound in 'foot' and 'strut' used to be pronounced the same, but then people in the south began pronouncing 'strut' differently. Danielle Turton, sociolinguist at Lancaster University, says the northern pronunciation is absolutely the original one. "It was the south that branched off and created this new vowel."

4 So, there you have it. While East Anglia may have been the home of the earliest English sounds, it did not stick to the original pronunciations like accents in northern England did. And while many think Received Pronunciation is an older-sounding English, in fact, it didn't exist until the 18th century. The north of England wins!

测验与练习

一、将标题和段落配对。

Paragraph 1 _____ Paragraph 2 _____ Paragraph 3 _____ Paragraph 4 _____ Paragraph 5 _____

a. The north-south divide b. A French invasion c. Britain's linguistic variation d. American English e. The origins of the English language f. The oldest English accent

二、根据文章内容选出正确的选项。

1. Which accent is typically associated with the English city of Liverpool? a. Mancunian b. Scouse c. Received Pronunciation

2. Old English is a mix of Germanic, Latin and Celtic languages. a. True b. False c. Not given

3. Old English had French influence. a. True b. False c. Not given   4. 'Blood', 'good', and 'food' have never rhymed. a. True b. False c. Not given

5. Which UK region is home to the oldest English accent? a. The north of England b. East Anglia c. The south of England

三、用下列单词完成对本文的总结。

Old English 1) _____ in East Anglia when Germanic 2) _____ invaded the British Isles. Many 3) _____ changes happened after that, until the arrival of the printing press meant that some spellings and pronunciations became 4) _____. This all changed with the 5) _____, where people across the country began pronouncing long vowel sounds differently.

originated linguistic tribes source Mancunian standardised Great Vowel Shift

(答案见词汇表后)

词汇表

Mancunian

曼彻斯特的，曼彻斯特方言的 Scouse 利物浦的，利物浦方言的 Received Pronunciation 标准英音，公认标准发音 social prestige 社会地位，社会声望 title 头衔 originate 起源，产生 tribe 部落 source 来源 absorb 吸收 linguistic 语言的，语言学的 standardised 标准化的 printing press 印刷机 rhyme 押韵 Great Vowel Shift 元音大推移 branch off 偏离，自立门户 there you have it 事情就是这样，这下你知道了吧

答案

一、将标题和段落配对。

Paragraph 1 c) Britain's linguistic variation Paragraph 2 e) The origins of the English language
Paragraph 3 a) The north-south divide Paragraph 4 f) The oldest English accent

二、根据文章内容选出正确的选项。

1. b. For instance, you can listen to Manchester's 'Mancunian' accent and then Liverpool's distinct 'Scouse' accent after just a 50-minute car or train ride.
2. a. True. Their Germanic languages mixed with existing Latin and Celtic languages and became Old English.
3. c. Not given. Old English may have had French influence, but it is not mentioned in the text.
4. b. False. Nowadays, the words 'blood', 'food' and 'good', which all contain two letter Os, sound different, but back then, they might have rhymed.
5. a. Danielle Turton, sociolinguist at Lancaster University, says the northern pronunciation is absolutely the original one . "It was the south that branched off and created this new vowel."

三、用下列单词完成对本文的总结。

Old English originated in East Anglia when Germanic tribes invaded the British Isles. Many linguistic changes happened after that, until the arrival of the printing press meant that some spellings and pronunciations became standardised . This all changed with the Great Vowel Shift , where people across the country began pronouncing long vowel sounds differently. 

内容版权归 BBC Learning English 所有，数据经 cooltv.top 获取，仅供个人学习使用。

原文：<https://www.bbc.co.uk/learningenglish/chinese/features/take-away-english/ep-260817>